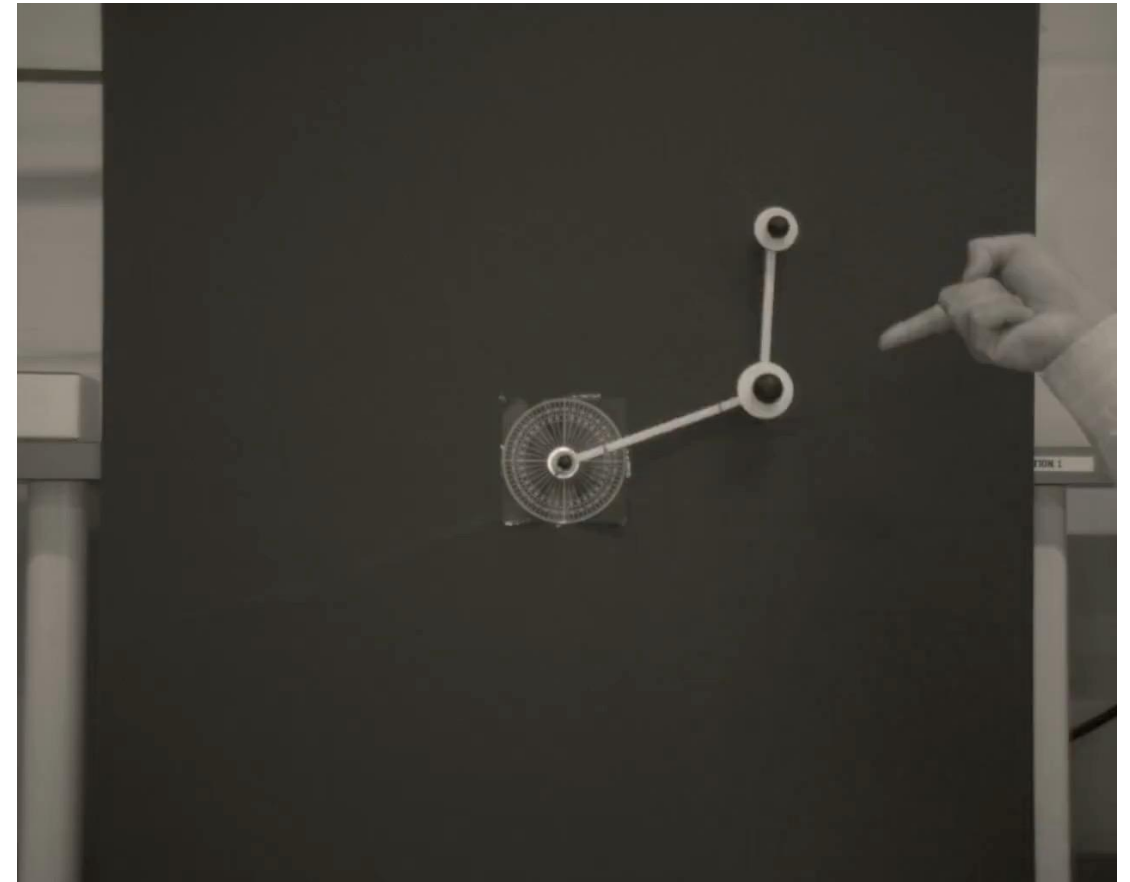


Double pendulum: motion, energy and measurement

Lecture 04 · MIE 402 · Fall 2026

A physical explanation of the model and the Lab 3 workflow.

Core lesson plus derivations for discussion and review.



The work students will do

Measure the two links and the masses attached to them.

Record at least four releases and track both moving bob centers.

Convert saved positions into angles and compare the measured motion with a simulation.

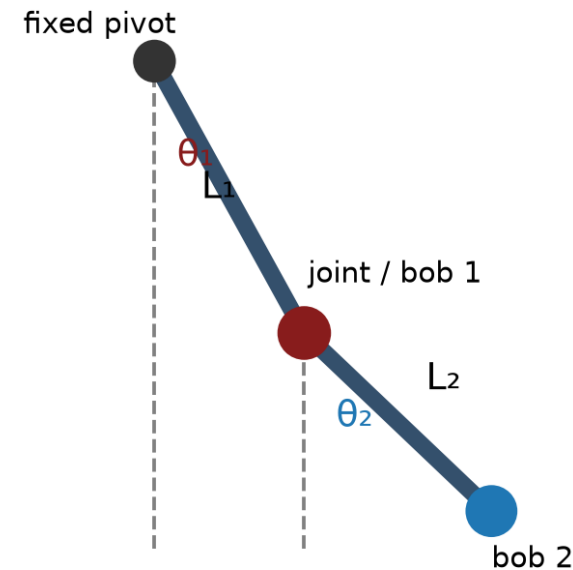
Keep the MP4, ExpData MAT file, settings and trial log for every release.

Two links and two absolute angles

The upper link joins the fixed pivot to the first joint.
The lower link joins that joint to bob 2.

Each angle starts at the downward vertical. Positive rotation moves the link toward the right.

The relative angle at the moving joint is $\theta_2 - \theta_1$. It is different from θ_2 .



Angles are absolute from downward vertical; θ_2 is not $\theta_2 - \theta_1$.

Masses and lengths in the model

m_1, m_2 [kg]: masses of the upper and lower uniform bars.

M_1 [kg]: lumped mass at the moving joint. M_2 [kg]: lumped mass at the lower bob.

L_1 [m]: fixed pivot to moving joint. L_2 [m]: moving joint to lower-bob center.

Assign each washer and attachment to one component only. Use measured values, not the pre-lab example.

Angles, angular speeds and accelerations

$$\omega_i = \dot{\theta}_i = \frac{d\theta_i}{dt} \quad \alpha_i = \ddot{\theta}_i$$

θ_i [rad] describes orientation. A dot means a time derivative, and i is 1 or 2.

ω_i [rad/s] tells how quickly the angle changes. α_i [rad/s²] tells how quickly that speed changes.

Use radians in the equations. Degrees are convenient labels for plots.

Positions follow from the geometry

$$x_1 = L_1 \sin \theta_1 \quad y_1 = -L_1 \cos \theta_1$$

$$x_2 = L_1 \sin \theta_1 + L_2 \sin \theta_2$$
$$y_2 = -L_1 \cos \theta_1 - L_2 \cos \theta_2$$

Choose the fixed pivot as (0,0), with x positive right and y positive upward.

Bob 2 moves because both links move. Its coordinates contain a contribution from each link.

Why we use energy to derive the model

Kinetic energy T is the energy of motion. Potential energy V comes from the height of every mass.

The total mechanical energy is $E = T + V$. The Lagrangian is $\mathcal{L} = T - V$.

The energy method includes the effect of joint forces without introducing every unknown internal force.

Baseline assumptions: rigid planar links, uniform bars, fixed pivot and no friction or air drag.

Potential energy begins with height

$$h_{G1} = \frac{L_1}{2} (1 - \cos \theta_1)$$

$$h_1 = L_1 (1 - \cos \theta_1)$$

$$h_{G2} = h_1 + \frac{L_2}{2} (1 - \cos \theta_2)$$

$$h_2 = h_1 + L_2 (1 - \cos \theta_2)$$

Set $V = 0$ when both links hang vertically downward.

Raising any mass by h increases its gravitational potential energy by mgh .

The center of a uniform bar lies halfway along it. The entire lower assembly also rises when link 1 rotates.

Potential energy of all four components

$$V = G_1(1 - \cos \theta_1) + G_2(1 - \cos \theta_2)$$

$$G_1 = \left(\frac{m_1}{2} + M_1 + m_2 + M_2\right)gL_1$$

$$G_2 = \left(\frac{m_2}{2} + M_2\right)gL_2$$

Add the energy of both bars and both lumped masses.

G_1 and G_2 are constants with units N·m, or joules. They collect mass, gravity and distance.

A larger mass or longer lever arm increases the energy needed to raise the system.

Gravity produces a restoring torque

$$Q_{g,i} = -\frac{\partial V}{\partial \theta_i} = -G_i \sin \theta_i$$

The derivative of potential energy gives the generalized gravitational torque.

For a small positive angle, the negative sign means gravity acts to reduce that angle.

Each G includes every mass whose height changes with the corresponding angle.

Kinetic energy of a moving bob

$$T_{bob\ 1} = \frac{1}{2} M_1 L_1^2 \omega_1^2$$

$$v_2^2 = L_1^2 \omega_1^2 + L_2^2 \omega_2^2 + 2L_1 L_2 \omega_1 \omega_2 \cos \Delta$$

For a point mass, $T = \frac{1}{2} Mv^2$. Bob 1 moves on a circle about the fixed pivot.

Bob 2 has the velocity of the moving joint plus its motion relative to that joint.

Squaring that sum produces a cross term. This is the origin of kinetic coupling.

A bar also carries kinetic energy

$$I_{center} = \frac{mL^2}{12} \quad I_{end} = \frac{mL^2}{3}$$
$$T_{bar\ 2} = \frac{1}{2}m_2v_{G2}^2 + \frac{1}{2}I_{G2}\omega_2^2$$

A uniform bar rotating about its end has moment of inertia $mL^2/3$.

The upper bar rotates about the fixed pivot. The lower bar also translates because its upper joint moves.

Include both translation of the center and rotation about the center for the lower bar.

Total kinetic energy

$$T = \frac{1}{2} I_{11} \omega_1^2 + \frac{1}{2} I_{22} \omega_2^2 + C \cos \Delta \omega_1 \omega_2$$

$$I_{11} = \left(\frac{m_1}{3} + M_1 + m_2 + M_2 \right) L_1^2$$

$$I_{22} = \left(\frac{m_2}{3} + M_2 \right) L_2^2$$

$$C = \left(\frac{m_2}{2} + M_2 \right) L_1 L_2$$

The first two terms account for motion associated with each angular speed.

The cross term accounts for the fact that both rotations contribute to the lower assembly's velocity.

I_{11} , I_{22} and C all have units $\text{kg} \cdot \text{m}^2$. They depend only on the apparatus masses and lengths.

Meaning of the coupling term

$$T_{cross} = C \cos(\theta_1 - \theta_2) \omega_1 \omega_2$$

$\Delta = \theta_1 - \theta_2$ measures the difference between the link orientations.

For aligned links moving in the same sense, the lower-bob velocity contributions reinforce each other.

Opposite angular speeds can partly cancel those contributions. The cross term may be negative, while total T remains nonnegative.

At $\Delta = 90^\circ$, this cross term is zero at that instant. Other dynamic coupling terms can still remain.

Energy during real and ideal motion

$$E = T + V \quad \frac{dE}{dt} = 0 \text{ (ideal model)}$$

$$\frac{dE}{dt} = Q_1\omega_1 + Q_2\omega_2 \text{ (with nonconservative torques)}$$

At release from rest, T is zero and all initial mechanical energy is potential energy.

As masses descend, some potential energy becomes kinetic energy. Both links exchange energy through their connection.

The ideal simulation conserves total E. Real pivot friction and air drag remove mechanical energy.

Energy loss in a recording does not by itself identify which loss mechanism dominates.

How energy gives the equations of motion

$$\frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \omega_i} \right) - \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \theta_i} = Q_i \quad i = 1, 2$$

Form $\mathcal{L} = T - V$, then apply the equation once for θ_1 and once for θ_2 .

The first term accounts for the rate of change of generalized momentum. The second accounts for how the energy changes with configuration.

For the ideal baseline, $Q_1 = Q_2 = 0$. A supplied numerical solver advances these equations in time.

The two coupled acceleration equations

$$I_{11}\alpha_1 + C \cos \Delta \alpha_2 = -C \sin \Delta \omega_2^2 - G_1 \sin \theta_1$$

$$C \cos \Delta \alpha_1 + I_{22}\alpha_2 = C \sin \Delta \omega_1^2 - G_2 \sin \theta_2$$

The same I_{11} , I_{22} , C , G_1 and G_2 from the energy expressions appear here.

The terms containing $\sin \Delta$ and squared angular speed arise because the geometry changes during motion.

Both angular accelerations must be solved together at each time step.

What the simulation code actually does

$$q = (\theta_1, \theta_2)^T \quad \alpha_i = \frac{d\omega_i}{dt}$$

Input: measured masses, lengths, two starting angles and two starting angular speeds.

At the current angles and speeds, calculate the two right-hand sides and the 2×2 inertia matrix.

Solve that small linear system for α_1 and α_2 , then advance the angles and speeds.

Students run the supplied solver. A small change in time step should not change the physical conclusion.

Small motion and normal modes

$$M_0 \ddot{q} + Kq = 0$$
$$M_0 = [I_{11}, C; C, I_{22}] \quad K = \text{diag}(G_1, G_2)$$

For angles close to zero, $\sin \theta \approx \theta$ and $\cos \Delta \approx 1$. Products of small quantities drop out.

The linear model has two normal modes: one largely moves the links together and the other largely moves them oppositely.

A general small release can contain both modes. The angle trace can therefore contain two frequencies.

How the two mode frequencies are found

$$q(t) = a \cos(\Omega t + \varphi)$$

$$\det(K - \Omega^2 M_0) = 0 \quad f = \frac{\Omega}{2\pi}$$

Ω is a mode angular frequency [rad/s]. It differs from the instantaneous speed $\omega_i(t)$.

Assume a sinusoidal motion with a fixed ratio of the two angle amplitudes.

The determinant condition gives two values of Ω^2 . Divide Ω by 2π to obtain frequency in hertz.

Large motion and initial conditions

At large angles, the small-angle approximation loses accuracy and the coupling changes throughout the swing.

Nearby starts can separate over time. Use the same model parameters when comparing them.

Release without a push and record both actual initial angles.

A short complicated trace can show sensitivity, but appearance alone does not prove mathematical chaos.

The four laboratory trials

Trial A: small nonzero angles, roughly aligned links, released from rest.

Trials B–D: at least three larger combinations of initial angles.

Include a pair of similar starts so that you can compare sensitivity.

For every trial log both initial angles, masses, lengths, capture frame rate and filenames.

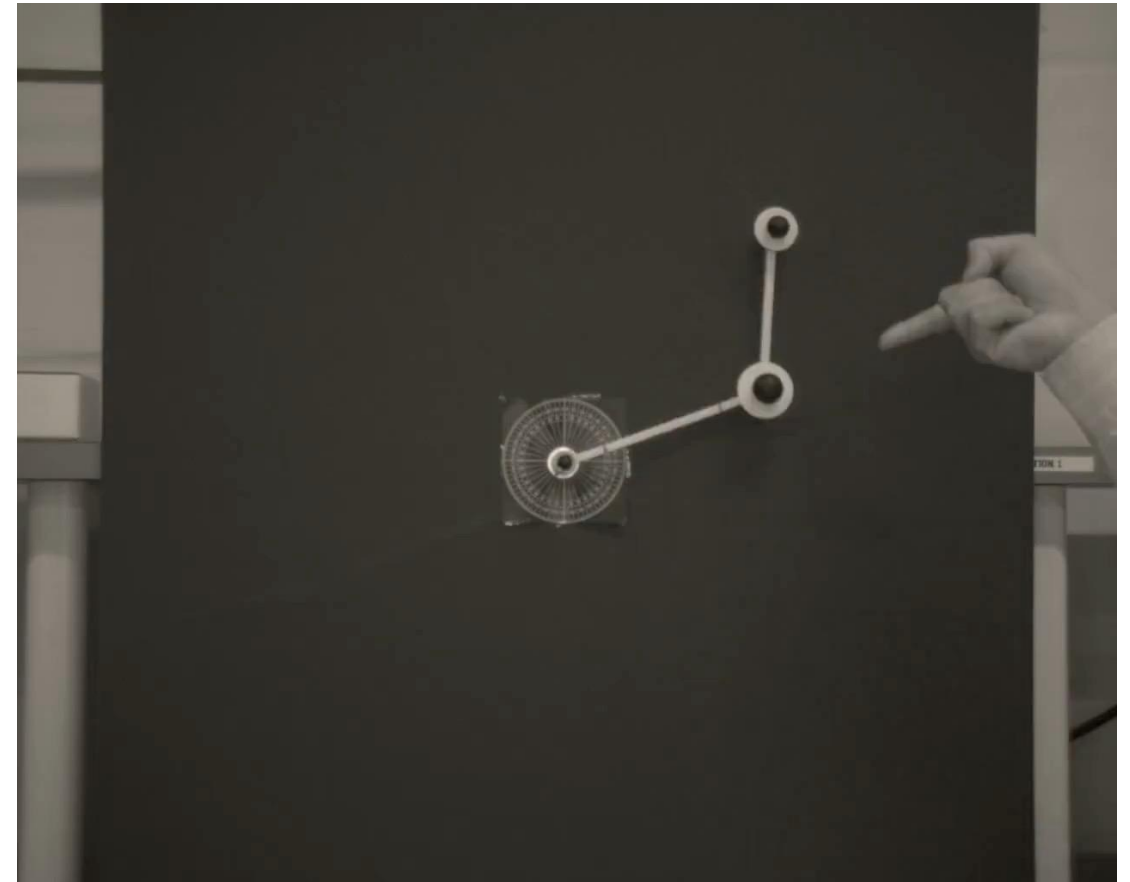
What the camera records

The camera records a sequence of images. The analyzer later extracts positions from them.

Use a dark background, bright bobs, sharp focus and enough framing for the whole motion.

The lab setup uses 1280×1024 and nominal 1000 capture frames/s. Record the actual setting.

Capture frame rate and MP4 playback rate can differ. Enter the capture rate in the analyzer.



Tracking both bobs

Select Double Pendulum in Pendulum Motion Analyzer V4.

Calibrate with a known distance and enter the actual capture frame rate.

Mark the fixed pivot and both bob centers. Inspect early, middle and late frames.

Use Quick Review to find problems, then Analyze All Frames and save results. Missing positions or a marker stuck on a fixed feature require correction.

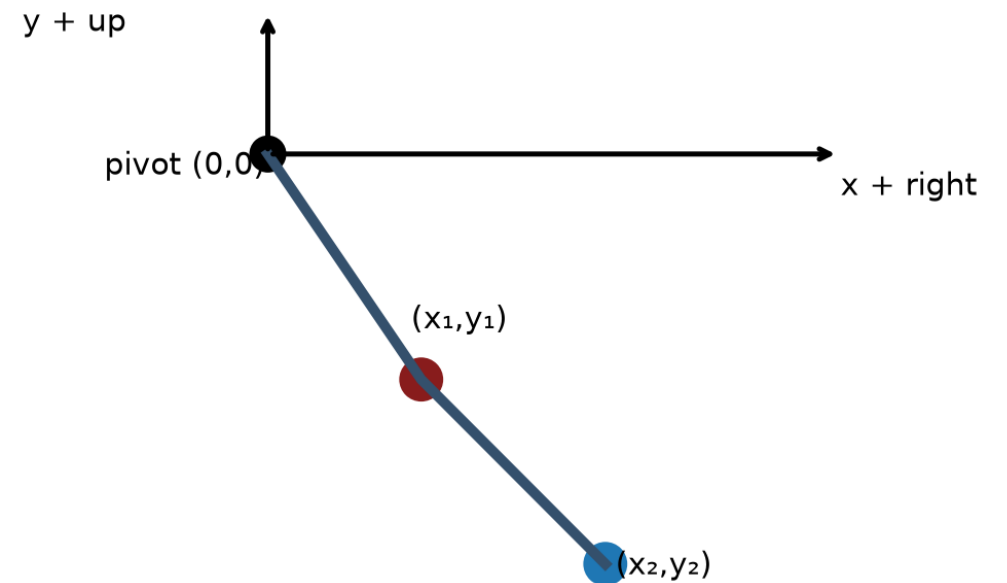
The coordinates in ExpData

Columns: time [s], x_1 [mm], y_1 [mm], x_2 [mm], y_2 [mm].

Coordinates are relative to the fixed pivot, with y positive upward.

The vector from bob 1 to bob 2 is $(x_2 - x_1, y_2 - y_1)$.
This vector gives the lower-link direction.

Inspect the saved MAT file before leaving the lab.
Keep the original MP4.



Positions become the two absolute angles

$$\theta_1 = \text{unwrap}(\text{atan2}(x_1, -y_1))$$

$$\theta_2 = \text{unwrap}(\text{atan2}(x_2 - x_1, -(y_2 - y_1)))$$

atan2 uses both vector components to identify the correct quadrant.

A downward link should give zero angle. Verify the sign using a known video frame.

Unwrapping removes artificial jumps at $\pm\pi$ when tracking continuous motion.

Angular velocity and frequency analysis

$$\omega_i = \frac{d\theta_i}{dt} \quad \Delta f = \frac{f_s}{N_s} = \frac{1}{T_r}$$

Angular velocity is the slope of the angle trace. Differentiation also amplifies tracking jitter.

FFT identifies frequency components over a finite record. Remove the mean before analysis.

Small motion may show two modal peaks. Large motion can have broader or changing spectral content.

State record length and analysis choices. A single global sine fit may be inappropriate.

Measured motion and the model

Use measured masses, lengths and starting conditions in the simulation.

Overlay both measured angles with their predictions and compare early timing and shape.

For a large-angle trial, explain how sensitive long-time agreement is to starting conditions.

Discuss release push, calibration, friction, air drag and motion out of the camera plane.

Pre-Lab 3 and the laboratory

Run the supplied notebook and answer six questions in one Word or PDF file. No student programming is required.

Compare one small release with two large releases separated by 1° at the start.

Read angle traces, their separation and the spectra. Explain the role of energy and coupling.

Use the pre-lab to plan measurements. Replace illustrative masses and lengths with your measured apparatus values.

The practical sequence in the lab

Measure and label the parts. Decide which mass belongs in each model parameter.

Set the camera and calibration, then record the four releases.

Review pivot and bob markers throughout each recording. Analyze all frames and save ExpData.

Generate two angle traces, two angular-velocity traces and spectra. Review one complete trial with the GTA.

Before leaving the laboratory

Save four trial labels and their measured initial conditions.

Record masses and lengths with units, capture frame rate and calibration distance.

Keep raw MP4 and ExpData MAT files for each trial.

Confirm that the complete analysis opens on your own computer and that the plotted trajectories are physically plausible.

Questions for discussion

If both links start at the same angle, must they remain aligned? Explain using the coupling.

Why does the lower assembly contribute to I_{11} as well as I_{22} ?

How would added lower-bob washers change kinetic and potential energy coefficients?

What observation distinguishes bad tracking from real complex motion?

Reference: remaining symbols and units

h_1, h_2 [m]: rise of each bob above its lowest position. hG_1, hG_2 [m]: rise of each bar center. $g = 9.81$ m/s² is gravitational acceleration.

Q_1, Q_2 [N·m]: generalized torques from effects excluded from V , such as friction. $Q_i\omega_i$ has units of power [W].

$q = (\theta_1, \theta_2)^T$ is the angle vector. a contains the two modal angle amplitudes; ϕ is the starting phase [rad].

f_s [Hz]: sampling rate of the analyzed data. N_s : number of samples. $T_r = N_s/f_s$ [s]: record duration for FFT bin spacing.

Δf [Hz]: spacing between FFT frequency bins. A longer record reduces Δf ; zero-padding alone does not improve physical resolution.